Clear Glass Marbles

By Jane Martin

The day my mother found out she was dying she asked me to go out and buy her these clear glass marbles. Dad and I hadn't even known she was ill. Which was nothing new. Whenever you asked my mother if she was ill she would throw things at you, sesame buns, the editorial page, a handful of hair ribbons. 'Do not,' she would say, 'suggest things to suggestible people.'

INTRODUCTION

But that's just what I intend to do today regarding the author of "Clear Glass Marbles" and the question is . . . . Who is Jane Martin? It is a mystery that has confounded the theatre community for over two decades. She has produced over ten full length plays, six one-acts, and numerous shorts. She has been nominated for the Pulitzer prize, and won the American Theatre Critics Association New Play Award twice. Yet, she has not made one public appearance. There are no interviews. No pictures. No sightings. Nothing. She has been called "America's best known unknown playwright." In her absence, retired Actors Theatre of Louisville artistic director Jon Jory has accepted her awards and served as her spokesman. Countless theatrical sleuths have tried to connect the dots, and they all seem to lead to Jory himself.

A clue to at least the "gender" of this elusive author may be found as you contemplate these "Clear Glass Marbles" by Jane Martin (aka Jon Jory?)

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I brought her the marbles and she counted out ninety of them and put them in this old cut-glass bowl which had been the sum total of great Aunt Helena's estate. The doctor had given her three months and she set great store by doctors. She said she always believed them because they were the nearest thing to the Old Testament we had. 'I wouldn't give you two bits for these young smiley guys,' she'd say, 'I go for a good, stern-furrowed physician.' She wouldn't even have her teeth cleaned by a dentist under fifty. So she counted out ninety clear glass marbles and

set them in the bowl on her bedside table. Then she went out and spent twelve hundred dollars on nightgowns. She said, 'In my family you are only dying when you take to your bed, and that, my darlings, is where I am going.' And she did. Dad said she couldn't possibly be dying but the doctors convinced him. I told her it seemed a little medieval to just lie up there but she said she didn't want to be distracted from what she loved. Us.

And she said there was nothing outside except drugstores and supermarkets and drycleaners and that given her situation they were beneath her dignity. I asked her what she intended to do up there and she said study French, visit with us, and maybe call a few pals. Study French. She said she had made a pledge to herself years ago that she would die bilingual.

Dad and I cried a lot, but she didn't. From then on the doctors had to come see her because, as she put it, she came in with a house call and she was going out with a house call. And all day, every day, she would hold one of these marbles in her hand. Why? She said it made the day longer. Mother had her own bedroom. That was the way it always was, for as long as I can remember. She called my father 'The Thrasher.' Dad could really get into a nightmare. Apparently early on in the marriage he had flipped over and broken her nose and that was it. Separate beds. Her room was very spare really. Wooden floors, and old steel-and-brass bed, oak dresser, bedside table, and a hat rack. No pictures on the walls. She never understood how people could look at the same darn thing day after day. She said it was bound to 'deflate the imagination.' We'd sit with her after dinner and talk about 'issues.' She told us she was too far gone for gossip or what we ate for lunch. Then we'd all go to bed and in a little while, just before I'd drift off I'd hear this…*(drops a marble) Happened every night. After the third of fourth day

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I saw one on the floor and started to pick it up but she said 'leave it.' She said it very sharply. I asked, 'How come?' She said she was 'learning to let go of them.' * (drops marble)

She made out a list of children's books from her own childhood and we got as many of them as we could find from the library. She said they were still the only good books she'd ever read. *(drops marble)

She wrote notes to, I don't know, maybe sixty or seventy people, and they told us later on that they were sort of little formal goodbyes, each of them recalling some incident or shared something, not very significant, but the odd thing was that in each one she included a recipe. A recipe in every one of them.

We got out the big cookie tin full of snapshots that somehow never became a scrapbook. She liked that. She showed my father how to do the medical insurance and how she handled the accounts. We even went through her jewelry. *(drops marble) She wrote down the names of the roofers and plumbers and air-conditioning people. She called it 'wrapping it up.' 'Well, this is good,' she'd say, 'I'm wrapping it up.' * (drops marble)

She had the television moved up in her room and she called aside to say that it was entirely possible that she might reach a stage where she really wouldn't know what she was watching but that I must promise her her that I'd keep it on P.B.S.

Later on, when it started getting hard, *(drops marble) she told Dad and me that she would like to spend more time alone. 'I'm afraid,' she said, 'that I'm going to have to do this more or less myself.' She said that she was glad, and she hoped we would be, that this was arranged so that you got less attached to the people you loved at the end. The next period isn't worth going into, it was just…hard. (pick up bowl of marbles) Do you know that from the very beginning down to the very last

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she never admitted to any pain. Never. She called it 'the chills.' The last thing she asked for was a picture we had in the front entrance hall of a Labrador retriever she and Dad had owned when they were first married. He was, she said, a perfectly dreadful dog. 'When you are young,' she said, 'you believe in the perfection of dogs.'

I was in bed two weeks ago Wednesday toward dawn, then this…(drop all marbles out of bowl, talk when they are done rolling) Dad and I ran in there. The bedside table was turned over and she was gone. Dead. When the emergency medical people got there the found this… (She opens her hand to disclose one more marble) The rest spilled when the table fell, but this one was still in her hand.

I keep it.

I keep it in my hand all day.

It makes the day longer.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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FORENSICS AWARDS

2002 National Qualifier – DI – Female
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